



Horror in the home

In the 1970s, movies such as *Halloween* and *The Exorcist* were praised for domesticating horror, bringing it out of the abandoned asylums and castles and into the home. Yet, 20 years earlier, *The Night of the Hunter* had already done this. Terror is built up during the movie as Powell ingratiates his way into John and Pearl's family, seducing their mother with his religious fervor. One by one, he violates the domestic norms that are supposed to make the children feel safe in his care. Rather than nurturing and feeding them as expected, he starves them in his attempt to make them confess where the money is hidden. The sense of menace becomes almost unbearable as he leads them

The widow Willa is won over by the phoney charm of the false preacher, who brings horror into her home.

down to the cellar by candlelight. These scenes terrify audiences because they tap into an innate fear: the violation of the home, the place where people should feel safe.

Fairy-tale ending

Eventually, the children are taken in by the kindly and wise Rachel Cooper (played by Hollywood veteran of the silent era Lillian Gish), an old woman who has adopted a number of children that have fallen victim to the Depression.

Like a fairy godmother, Rachel protects Pearl and John—but Powell is not yet finished, and the children are not yet safe.

The Night of the Hunter is hard to categorize, which may explain why, on its release, it was met with incomprehension. It is experimental, with close stylistic ties to German Expressionism. Scene after scene hovers on the cusp between dream and nightmare, real and surreal. Above all, it is a terrifying but hopeful fairy tale—candid in its depiction of the evil Powell, but also insistent on the possibility that evil can be fought. It is a story of love and hate, the words tattooed on Powell's knuckles. These two elemental forces collide in one of the most magical movies ever made. ■

“**Salvation** is a last-minute business, boy.”

Harry Powell / The Night of the Hunter



Charles Laughton
Director

Charles Laughton was born in 1899 in Scarborough, in the north of England. He trained at RADA, the London dramatic arts academy, which enabled him to get his first acting work on the London stage.

He made his Hollywood movie debut with the 1932 movie *The Old Dark House*, starring opposite Boris Karloff. His most iconic role came a year later, starring as the title character in *The Private Life of Henry VIII*, a performance that won him the Academy Award for best actor in 1933. Laughton went on to star in such movies as *Mutiny on the Bounty* (1935), *Jamaica Inn* (1939), and *Spartacus* (1960).

Laughton's only foray into directing was with *The Night of the Hunter*. Although it has gained critical mass over the years, the movie's initial box-office failure discouraged him, and he did not direct again. He died in California in 1962.

Key movie

1955 *The Night of the Hunter*